are also anti-national … So long as the Christians indulge in such activities and consider themselves as agents of international movement for the spread of Christianity, and refuse to offer their first loyalty to the land of their birth … they will remain here as hostile [sic] have to be treated as such.'[140] Much like it did in the tribal areas of Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh (see Chapter 14), the RSS chose to focus on education and the setting up of a wide network of schools in the Northeast as a tool to counter what it saw as the threat of Christian expansion. It is to this story that we now turn.

SANKAR DEVA NIKETANS, ABVKA AND EKAL VIDYALAYAS: EDUCATION AS A CULTURAL TOOL

Education is a key focus of the RSS's deep expansion into the Northeast. In 2016, Himanta Biswa Sarma tweeted a picture of himself with Sarfaraz Hussain, a tea-shop employee's son who had topped the state's CBSE board examination. A Muslim student, he had graduated from the Sankardev Shishu Niketan, scoring 590 out of 600 marks. This network of schools, named after the fifteenth-century Assamese poet-saint Sri Sankar Deva, is known as Saraswati Shishu Mandir in other states[141] and is run by the Sangh Parivar's Vidya Bharati network, which was set up in 1977. Sarma, then education minister of Assam, announced that schools with RSS ideals would soon be set up in each of the 2,202 panchayats in Assam.[142] Whether that happens or not, the Sangh Parivar was already running hundreds of schools across the Northeast. By 2020, Vidya Bharati was running 578 schools in Assam, with 16,347 students. Across seven north-eastern states, it ran a total of 670 schools—all geo-located on its website—with 28,488 students and 9,510 teachers,. A vast majority of these were in Assam (578), followed by Arunachal Pradesh (thirty), Sikkim (twenty-four), Meghalaya (eighteen), Manipur (twelve), Tripura (five) and Nagaland (three).

Table 16.8: Vidya Bharati Schools in the Northeast

State	*Schools*	*Students*	*Teachers*
Assam	578	16,347	8,775
Arunachal Pradesh	30	3,123	293